During the summer of 2012, Suu Kyi visited Europe and spoke at a meeting of the International Labor Organization (ILO) in Geneva, Switzerland. This stop was followed by the belated acceptance of the Nobel Peace Prize in Oslo, Norway. On June 21, she addressed a joint meeting of the British Parliament, an honor that has been bestowed on few individuals in recent decades. Following her stay in Britain, she traveled to Ireland for a meeting with rock icon Bono. The trip ended with several days in France, where she met with French President Francois Hollande.

Aung San Suu Kyi was submitting works to the Myanmar media. One of the weekly publications, *The Messenger*, ran an interview and cover story about Aung San Suu Kyi. Furthermore, open access to key foreign publications was now available.

It seems apparent that Thein Sein is committed to the changes outlined in his inaugural statement in March 2011. The policy changes have been clearly laid out and a timeline is also in place. Furthermore, the president has also been realistic in his plan, stating the possible obstacles that the regime may need to overcome. Observers within the government as well as outside observers sense a real commitment to change and an eagerness to hear constructive criticism.

Thein Sein had solidified his hold on power, making reform possible. Numerous conservative figures within the previous government were marginalized. It is uncertain whether these individuals were removed from positions, reassigned to other posts within the government, or convinced that change was in the best interest for the future of Myanmar.

Thein Sein's break from Than Shwe's policies was extremely noteworthy. An example of this break has been the restoration of the legacy of Aung San. When the president met with Aung San Suu Kyi he made certain that the photo opportunity took place directly in front of Aung San's portrait in Naypyidaw. Than Shwe felt that by promoting Aung San he would be indirectly helping to legitimize the opposition, including his daughter. The policy of “downgrading” Aung San included taking his photo off of banknotes, deemphasizing the annual Martyrs' Day celebration, and restricting access to his mausoleum. Most experts believe Than Shwe is totally removed from any role in decision making, with dramatically reduced power.